



MOSCOW RUSSIA

Russia's Superpowered Soup

Moscow is a city where fusion isn't just a style of cuisine, but the leitmotif of local gastronomy. Even fast-food chains sell a range of sushi, Thai, Chinese, and Italian dishes to tempt Muscovites. This "mix and match" approach might seem new, but it goes back centuries – as does the Russian love of soup – and the two combine in *solyanka*, a soup that can feature almost anything.



Conspicuous consumption is the credo of this city, which revolves around power and money, and sees excess as a virtue. The global recession may

have halted the construction of the world's tallest skyscraper, but menus still feature dubious exotica such as endangered species smuggled out of African war zones. From historic Red Square to the fashionable malls of the Garden Ring road, this febrile city has re-created and reimagined itself to become "the new New York." Radiating in concentric circles from its medieval hilltop citadel, or Kremlin, Moscow exemplifies the best and worst of Russia. Its beauty and ugliness are inseparable, its sentimentality the obverse of a brutality rooted in centuries of despotism and fear of anarchy. Private and cultural life is as passionate as business and politics are cynical.

Eating well has always been not only an affirmation of success but also a way of fortifying oneself for the hardships that may befall even the richest. As illustrated by the fate of Bolshevik leaders in Stalin's day, even the greatest can end up in Siberia – so it's important to enjoy life while you can. Traditionally, the main meal of the day has been *obyyed* (lunch), with supper limited to

leftover *zakuski* – Russian hors d'oeuvres (see p75). Even today, when slimmed-down business lunches are widely available, many Muscovites expect to eat a hearty four-course lunch of *zakuski*, soup, a main dish, and a dessert, washed down with beer or vodka.

Soup has always been the mainstay of Russian cuisine; spoons appeared on Russian tables 400 years before forks did. Peasants subsisted on cabbage soup and buckwheat porridge, with flavorings limited to sour cream, garlic, honey, vinegar, dill, and a few other fresh herbs. These tastes – salty, sweet, sour, and pickled – remained the norm even among the nobility until Peter the Great introduced French chefs to his court. *Solyanka* is a rich jumble of a soup that combines indigenous with foreign ingredients. Its name derives from the Russian word for salt (*sol*), but it also means "mixed" due to the wide variety of possible ingredients. The soup is prepared by cooking salted cucumbers, before adding the main ingredient: meat, mushrooms, or fish. The core ingredient dictates what else goes in, from allspice and dill to cabbage and breadcrumbs. Like a Dostoevskian fictional hero, cast aside any doubts and throw yourself wholeheartedly into the dish and into Moscow itself – you're sure to leave poorer but wiser.

A Day in Moscow

Be sure to travel between sights on Moscow's metro, deservedly famous for the lavish decor of its stations. Ploshchad Revolyutsii, Komsomolskaya, Park Kultury, and Mayakovskaya are among the best examples of the grandiose, High Stalinist style.

MORNING Visit **Red Square**, whose iconic **St. Basil's Cathedral** and **Lenin Mausoleum** symbolize Russia's tumultuous past, as does the **Kremlin**. See the crown jewels in the **Armory Museum**, the colossal **Czar Cannon**, and the world's largest bell before lunch at the nearby Shield and Sword restaurant (see facing page).

AFTERNOON Take a cruise on the **Moskva River**, past the fairy-tale **Cathedral of Christ the Savior** and the 300-ft- (91-m-) high **Monument to Peter the Great**, bestriding a galleon. Disembark at the **Novodevichy Convent** to visit the cemetery where Gogol, Shostakovich, and other luminaries are buried beneath quirky effigies.

EVENING See what's happening on the scene at **Garage**, a wonderful Constructivist bus depot turned art space, like the Tate Modern's Turbine Hall in London.

Essentials

GETTING THERE

Domodedovo International **airport** is 22 miles (34 km) from the center of the city; there are regular Aeroexpress **trains** to the downtown.

WHERE TO STAY

Alfa (inexpensive) is a 3-star giant 20 minutes from downtown. www.hotelizmailovo-alfa.ru/eng
Akvarel (moderate) is very central, located off chic Tverskaya Ulitsa. www.hotelakvarel.ru
Savoy (expensive) is a historic 4-star hotel with an Art Nouveau restaurant and a sauna, extensively restored in 2005. www.savoy.ru

FURTHER INFORMATION

www.visitrussia.com; www.moscowcity.com

